major infantry sortie, only to be immediately attacked by a strong force of Afghan cavalry who rode straight down through his ranks. ‘The Afghans gathered their strength and charged downhill and mowed down hundreds of English soldiers like grass,’ recorded Mirza ‘Ata. ‘Bravery and death were to be seen on both sides.’[69]

Only after leaving eighty of their troops dead on the ground, and with nearly 200 wounded, did the British succeed in spiking one gun and dragging the other back within the cantonment walls.[70] It was not a good precedent for the effectiveness of the terrified garrison against their increasingly confident and emboldened besiegers.

On 15 November, British morale received another blow when two ragged figures broke through the ring of besiegers to bring terrible news. Eldred Pottinger and John Haughton were apparently the only two survivors of the 750-strong garrison of Charikar.

After ten days of siege, driven mad by thirst, made anxious by the growing stream of desertions, and by the growing numbers of Tajiks and Safis massing to join the siege of the barracks, Pottinger had decided that the only hope was to try to make a dash for Kabul. ‘The corps was completely disorganised from the privations it had suffered, the utter inefficiency of the native officers who had no sort of control over their soldiers, the exhaustion of the men from constant duty, and the total want of water and provisions,’ he wrote later. ‘I therefore considered that our only chance of saving any portion of the Regiment was a retreat on Kabul and though that was abundantly perilous, I entertained a hope that the most active men who were not encumbered with wives and children might make it through in safety.’

But, as with Mackenzie’s night retreat from the commissariat fort, chaos reigned almost from the minute Pottinger’s troops dashed from the building. ‘I found it totally impossible to preserve any order after leaving the gate and in vain attempted leading the men,’ he confessed in his official report.[71] The fleeing soldiers were shot down as they ran madly to try to find water. All 300 of the wounded who were left behind, as well as any of the sepoys or their wives captured alive, were distributed among the Tajik chiefs and immediately sold as slaves.[72]